Comparative Evaluation of Methods for Position-Independent Voiced-Consonant Detection in Isolated Words

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Abstract—This paper presents a comparative evaluation of methods for position-independent full-word detection of four voiced consonants, d, n, r, and v, using recordings from Speech Commands v0.02. The target consonant may appear at the beginning, middle, or end of the word, so the detection problem is formulated as letter presence over the whole active word. A 19-keyword benchmark is constructed so that each target consonant has exactly four positive keyword types while the targets still occur in initial, medial, and final positions across the benchmark. We compare five classical detectors and one multilayer perceptron (MLP) baseline: global fast Fourier transform (FFT) template matching, Mel-frequency cepstral coefficient (MFCC) mean-template scanning, MFCC + dynamic time warping (DTW), local short-time Fourier transform (STFT) mean-template scanning, local STFT k-nearest-neighbor (k-NN) scanning, and a small MLP operating on full-word log-Mel features. The FFT/STFT spectrum detectors are implemented in MATLAB, while the MFCC/DTW and MLP detectors provide comparison methods from speech recognition and neural-network modeling. On balanced speaker-independent test sets, the classical methods achieve macro F1 between 66.18% and 67.85%, while the MLP reaches 86.25% macro F1 and 86.46% macro accuracy. In these experiments, coarse template detectors have high recall but poor precision under word-level labels and weak phoneme alignment, whereas the trained MLP gives a sharper full-word decision boundary.

I. Introduction

Speech is a time-domain waveform, but many phonetic cues become much clearer after short-time spectral analysis. Sampling, Fourier analysis, and local spectra make physically meaningful structure visible. This work uses those tools as part of a controlled comparison of detectors for deciding whether selected voiced consonants are present in spoken isolated words. Speech Commands v0.02 is a public corpus of short, single-word speech recordings designed for limited-vocabulary keyword-spotting research; here it is used as a source of isolated-word utterances with word labels.

The critical methodological issue is position. A target consonant can occur in different parts of an isolated word, for example d in dog and bed, or r in right and zero. Therefore, we study position-independent detection of four voiced consonants:

- d: voiced alveolar stop,
- n: voiced nasal stop,
- r: voiced liquid,
- v: voiced labiodental fricative.

The comparative study is organized around three questions:

1) How can local spectral templates be extracted for consonants in word-level recordings?
2) How well do classical spectrum, Mel-frequency cepstral coefficient (MFCC), and dynamic time warping (DTW) detectors work when the target consonant may occur anywhere in the word?
3) How does a multilayer perceptron (MLP) classifier trained directly on whole-word features compare with the classical detectors?

The contribution is a controlled comparison of six detectors on the same 19-keyword Speech Commands benchmark, with identical letter labels, speaker-independent splits, and metrics. Local target templates are constructed from approximate phoneme-position priors, and each local detector scans the entire active part of the word at test time.

II. Related Work

Classical speech recognition relied heavily on short-time spectral analysis and template matching. Rabiner and Schafer describe the central role of short-time processing in speech analysis [1]. Davis and Mermelstein introduced MFCCs as a compact and effective spectral representation for speech recognition [2]. Sakoe and Chiba proposed DTW to align speech templates under speaking-rate variability [3]. These ideas motivate the MFCC and DTW baselines used here.

Modern speech systems increasingly use learned models rather than direct template matching. Hinton et al. summarized the impact of deep neural networks on acoustic modeling [4]. For limited-vocabulary speech tasks, Sainath and Parada showed that compact neural networks can outperform conventional baselines in keyword spotting [5]. Speech Commands was introduced by Warden as a public benchmark for limited-vocabulary keyword spotting and has been widely used to evaluate isolated-word speech recognition methods [6].

Our comparison therefore includes MATLAB spectrum methods based on the fast Fourier transform (FFT) and short-time Fourier transform (STFT), MFCC/DTW baselines, and an MLP trained on the same Speech Commands recordings.

III. Problem Formulation and Theory

A. Sliding-Window Letter Detection

Let $x[n]$ be a word recording and let $[t_s, t_e]$ denote its active speech region after simple energy-based voice activity detection. We slide a fixed analysis window across that active region and obtain local segments

$$w_m[n] = x[n + t_m], \quad m = 1, \ldots, M. \tag{1}$$

For a target consonant c, a template bank $B_c = \{b_{c,1}, \ldots, b_{c,K_c}\}$ is built from training recordings. A generic scan detector uses

$$S_c(x) = \max_m g_c(\phi(w_m), B_c), \tag{2}$$

where $\phi(\cdot)$ is the chosen local feature map and g_c is the method-dependent bank score: maximum cosine similarity, negative DTW distance, or top-k average cosine similarity. The final decision is

$$\hat{y}_c(x) = \begin{cases} 1, & S_c(x) \geq \tau_c, \\ 0, & S_c(x) < \tau_c, \end{cases} \tag{3}$$

with threshold τ_c chosen on the validation set.

B. Approximate Phoneme-Position Prior

Speech Commands provides word labels but not phoneme boundaries. To initialize target templates, we map each selected keyword to a simple ARPABET (ARPA phonetic alphabet) pronunciation and approximate the target-phoneme center by a uniform partition of the active word. If a word has L phonemes and the target occurs at zero-based phoneme index i, we estimate its center as

$$\hat{t}_i = t_s + \frac{i + 0.5}{L}(t_e - t_s). \tag{4}$$

This weak alignment assumption is used only during training to choose template windows. Word labels are also used to define positive and negative examples and to compute ground-truth evaluation metrics. They are not used as inputs to the detector at test time: the detector receives only the waveform-derived spectral features and then scans the whole active region.

C. Short-Time Spectrum, MFCC, and DTW

For a frame window $h[n]$, the short-time Fourier transform (STFT) is

$$X_{w,r}[k] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} w[n + rH]h[n]e^{-j2\pi kn/N}. \tag{5}$$

For each scanned 100 ms analysis window, the local STFT feature is constructed by computing the log-magnitude STFT inside that window and then averaging over its short-time frames:

$$\phi_{\text{STFT}}(w)[k] = \frac{1}{M_w} \sum_{r=1}^{M_w} \log\left(|X_{w,r}[k]| + \epsilon\right). \tag{6}$$

Thus $\phi_{\text{STFT}}(w)$ is a single spectrum vector describing the local frequency content of one consonant-sized region of the word. The local STFT detectors compare this vector with target-consonant templates using cosine similarity. This keeps the detector directly interpretable in the frequency domain.

Mel-frequency cepstral coefficients (MFCCs) compress the short-time spectrum into a perceptually motivated cepstral representation. If $E_m[b]$ is the Mel-band energy of frame m and band b, then

$$c_m[q] = \sum_{b=0}^{B-1} \log E_m[b] \cos\left(\frac{\pi(b + 1/2)q}{B}\right). \tag{7}$$

Dynamic time warping (DTW) then compares two MFCC sequences by the minimum dynamic-programming path cost under local step constraints [3]. In our detector, DTW is applied between every scanned test window and a small bank of representative target templates.

D. MLP Detector

For the multilayer perceptron (MLP) method, each full word is converted into a resized log-Mel spectrogram vector $z(x)$. We train one binary MLP per target consonant:

$$p_c(x) = \sigma(W_2 \rho(W_1 \tilde{z}(x) + b_1) + b_2), \tag{8}$$

where $\tilde{z}(x)$ is standardized, $\rho(\cdot)$ is the rectified linear unit (ReLU), and $\sigma(\cdot)$ is the sigmoid function. This model sees the entire word at once and is not limited to one local template.

IV. Dataset and Experimental Setup

A. Dataset and Target Selection

We use the full Speech Commands v0.02 dataset [6]. From it, we select 19 keywords: backward, bed, bird, cat, dog, five, four, go, house, marvin, no, on, right, seven, up, visual, wow, yes, and zero. Six of these keywords, cat, go, house, up, wow, and yes, do not contain any of the four target consonants and are included as target-free negative examples. To keep the computation comparable across all methods, each keyword is capped at 150 training recordings, 60 validation recordings, and 120 test recordings, giving 6,270 recordings in total. Speaker-independent splits use the hexadecimal filename token before _nohash_: after conversion to an integer and modulo 100, buckets 0–19, 20–29, and 30–99 are test, validation, and training, respectively, giving about 70%/10%/20% train/validation/test before caps.

Table I shows the positive keywords for each target consonant. The labels I/M/F denote initial, medial, and final target positions in the approximate pronunciation. The positive keyword design is lexically balanced: each target consonant appears in exactly four selected keyword types. Some words contain more than one target consonant, so they can be positive examples for more than one binary detector.

TABLE I: Target consonants, phonetic roles, and positive keyword set used in the experiments

Target	Phonetic role	Positive keywords used for detection
d	voiced alveolar stop	backward(F), bed(F), bird(F), dog(I)
n	voiced nasal stop	marvin(F), no(I), on(F), seven(F)
r	voiced liquid	four(F), marvin(M), right(I), zero(M)
v	voiced labiodental fricative	five(F), marvin(M), seven(M), visual(I)

For each target consonant, the word label is converted into a binary presence label using the pronunciation table. For example, marvin is positive for n, r, and v, but negative for d. The negative class is sampled from the remaining selected keywords that do not contain that target. The negative examples are subsampled to match the number of positive examples, so every detection problem is balanced. During testing, these labels are used only to score the predictions, not to generate them.

B. Assumptions and Preprocessing

The experiments use the following assumptions:

- Speech Commands provides word labels but not phoneme boundaries.
- Active speech can be isolated by an energy threshold on 20 ms frames with 10 ms hop.
- Approximate phoneme timing can be estimated by dividing the active region according to pronunciation length.
- Detection is position-independent at test time, so all local methods scan the full active word.

Each recording is mean-removed and peak-normalized. The active region is then detected by thresholding short-time energy at 10% of the utterance maximum. Local detectors use a 100 ms analysis window, a 25 ms STFT frame, 10 ms hop, and 512-point FFT. MFCC features use 26 Mel filters and 13 cepstral coefficients.

C. Implemented Methods

We compare six methods. The global FFT, local STFT mean-template, and local STFT k-nearest-neighbor (k-NN) detectors form the MATLAB spectrum-based implementation. MFCC mean-template and MFCC + DTW are speech-recognition baselines, and the MLP is trained for the same detection task. The MLP is included as a learned whole-word baseline, not as an a priori preferred method; all methods use the same train/validation/test protocol. Table II summarizes the models, assumptions, and decision rules.

Figure 1 connects the method names to the algorithmic blocks. A method is a concrete feature and scoring choice, while an algorithm block is a reusable procedure. Thus, four local template methods share the same template-building and full-word scanning structure, while differing in feature representation and similarity score.

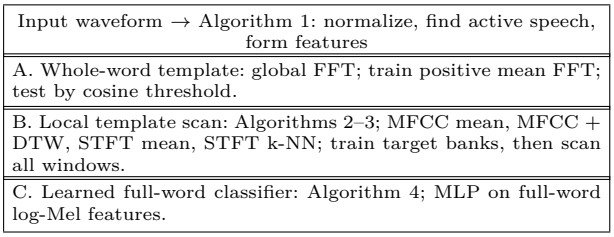

Fig. 1: Block diagram linking the six implemented methods to the four shared algorithm structures. Algorithm 2 builds classical templates and Algorithm 3 scores test recordings.

D. Algorithm Structure

The algorithmic structure is summarized in Fig. 1. Algorithm 1 is common preprocessing: waveform normalization, active-speech detection, and generation of full-word and local-window features. Algorithm 2 builds classical templates: the global FFT method averages positive whole-word spectra, while the local methods build target-window banks using the approximate phoneme-position prior in (4). Algorithm 3 scores classical test recordings by thresholding either the whole-word FFT cosine score or the best local-window cosine, DTW, or k-NN score. Algorithm 4 trains one standardized full-word log-Mel MLP per target consonant and thresholds its output probability.

V. Spectral Analysis

Figure 2 shows the average local spectra extracted from the estimated target windows. Even with weak phoneme alignment, the targets remain distinguishable. The stop consonant d shows a short transition-like spectrum, n concentrates more low-frequency energy because of nasal resonance, r has a smoother vowel-like transition, and v contributes frication energy from a voiced labiodental constriction.

Figure 3 validates the task definition by showing highlighted windows at different target positions: d is captured at the end of bed, n at the end of seven, r in the middle of zero, and v at the beginning of visual. These examples illustrate the full-word scanning problem.

VI. Results and Comparisons

A. Overall Comparison

Table III reports the average precision, recall, F1, and accuracy over the four balanced binary detection tasks. The average metrics show that the classical detectors are

TABLE II: Implemented methods, feature spaces, assumptions, and decision rules

Method	Feature / model	Training assumptions and structure	Test-time decision rule
Global FFT template	Whole active-word log FFT spectrum	Build one positive mean template per letter from whole-word spectra; threshold tuned on validation set	Detect the letter if cosine similarity to the positive template exceeds the tuned threshold
MFCC mean-template scan	13-dimensional MFCC mean of each 100 ms local window	Use pronunciation-based target windows to form initial/medial/final positive template means	Scan the active word and take the maximum cosine similarity over all windows and templates
MFCC + DTW	Sequence of MFCC vectors inside each 100 ms local window	Use pronunciation-based target windows to form a representative positive bank; tune template count and Sakoe–Chiba band on validation data	Scan the active word and use the negative minimum DTW distance as the score
Local STFT mean-template scan	Average local log spectrum of each 100 ms window	Use pronunciation-based target windows to form initial/medial/final positive spectral templates	Scan the active word and take the maximum cosine similarity over all windows and templates
Local STFT k-NN scan	Bank of local average log spectra	Store representative target windows; tune k on validation data	Scan the active word and use the best top-k average cosine similarity as the score
MLP classifier	Whole-word resized log-Mel spectrogram vector	Train one binary MLP per letter with ReLU, sigmoid output, Adam, and early stopping	Use the output probability and a validation-tuned threshold to decide letter presence

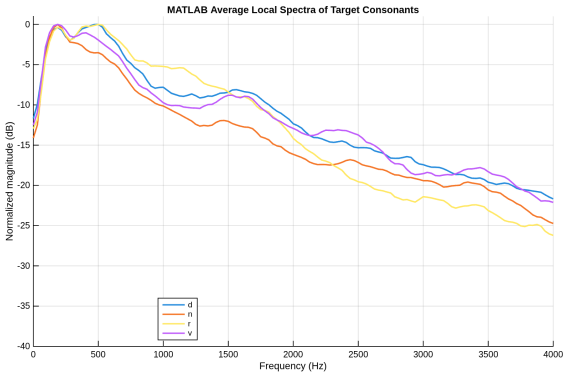

Fig. 2: MATLAB average local spectra of the four voiced consonants extracted from approximate target windows.

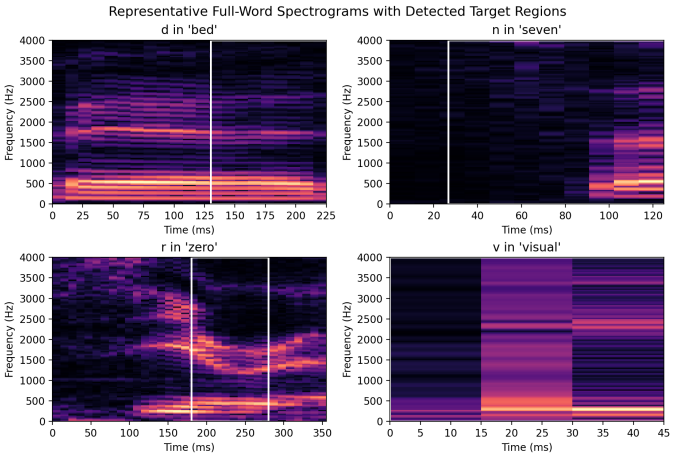

Fig. 3: Representative full-word spectrograms with highlighted target windows. The examples include initial, final, and medial consonant positions.

recall-heavy but imprecise, while the MLP gives more balanced precision and recall.

The MATLAB spectrum implementation was also run separately for the FFT/STFT detectors. It gave comparable macro F1 values: 66.65% for global FFT, 66.02% for local STFT mean-template scanning, and 65.93% for local STFT k-NN scanning. These values agree with Table III: classical spectrum scanning is useful for spectral interpretation, but in this benchmark it is less selective than the MLP under weak phoneme alignment.

Figure 4 presents the same comparison graphically. The five classical methods cluster closely together because they all depend on weakly aligned target templates. Once the target is allowed to occur anywhere in the word, coarse positive-template scanning becomes difficult to make selective.

B. Per-Letter Comparison

Figure 5 compares one MFCC/DTW baseline, one local-spectrum classical detector (STFT k-NN), and the MLP on each letter. In the test results, the MLP obtains the highest F1 for all four consonants: 86.39% for d, 80.63% for n, 88.98% for r, and 89.00% for v.

Among the classical methods, performance is especially limited for letters whose target windows are hard to isolate with only word-level supervision. This is expected: the classical detectors know how the target should look locally, but they do not learn a global representation of the entire word.

C. Discussion

The experiments lead to three main conclusions.

1) Weak phoneme alignment is the main bottleneck for classical detectors. The classical methods achieve recall

TABLE III: Average detection performance across the four target consonants on the speaker-independent test split

Method	Macro precision (%)	Macro recall (%)	Macro F1 (%)	Macro accuracy (%)
Global FFT template	50.38	99.22	66.82	50.73
MFCC mean-template scan	53.12	94.64	67.85	55.03
MFCC + DTW	51.18	96.04	66.72	52.08
Local STFT mean-template scan	51.82	94.11	66.65	52.92
Local STFT k-NN scan	51.87	91.82	66.18	53.15
MLP classifier	86.87	86.04	86.25	86.46

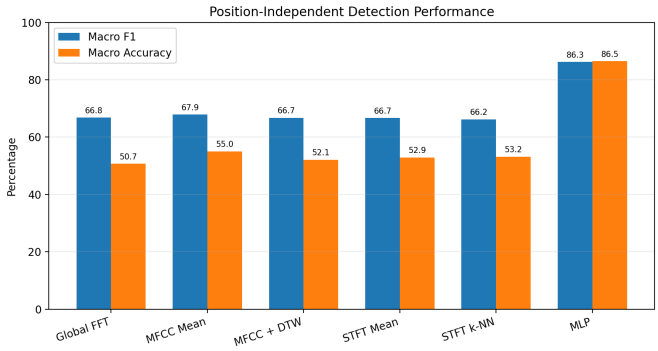

Fig. 4: Macro F1 and macro accuracy for all implemented methods. Percentage labels are printed above the bars to make close classical baseline values readable.

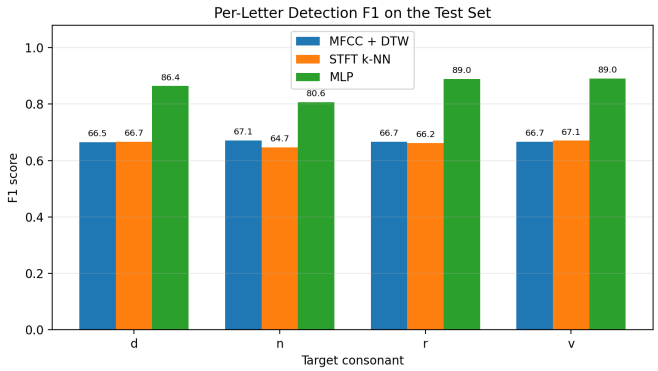

Fig. 5: Per-letter detection F1 for an MFCC/DTW baseline, a local-spectrum baseline, and the MLP classifier. Percentage labels are printed above the bars.

around 92–99%, but precision only around 50–53%. They often find a spectrally similar local region somewhere in the word, even when the target consonant is absent. This high-recall/low-precision behavior is consistent with positive-template scanning under approximate target localization.

2) MFCC/DTW baselines and spectrum baselines are both informative. MFCC mean-template and MFCC + DTW represent standard speech-recognition feature and alignment methods. Global FFT, local STFT mean-template, and local STFT k-NN are MATLAB spectrum methods based on direct Fourier analysis. In the full-word setting, none of the classical methods dominates decisively; all are constrained by the same lack of exact phoneme boundaries.

3) The MLP gives the highest scores in this study. The MLP sees the entire log-Mel representation of the word and learns nonlinear boundaries between positive and negative examples. In the measured results, its macro F1 is 86.25%, compared with roughly 66–68% for the classical methods, and its precision and recall are more balanced.

The main limitation is that target timing is approximate rather than forced-aligned, and the balanced design uses only four positive keyword types per target consonant.

VII. Conclusion

This work analyzed the spectra of four voiced consonants in MATLAB, implemented MATLAB spectrum-based detectors, evaluated MFCC/DTW baselines, and trained an MLP on Speech Commands recordings. The task is formulated as position-independent letter detection inside words.

Under that formulation, the five classical detectors all show similar high-recall/low-precision behavior, while the MLP gives the highest measured result with 86.25% macro F1 and 86.46% macro accuracy. Overall, Fourier-based spectrum tools remain useful for spectral interpretation and baseline detection, but once target timing becomes uncertain, learned whole-word representations can be more robust than weakly aligned local templates.

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